Programmes (SAP). As the market logic is extended to the public sector, the state becomes a regulator rather than a provider of such services. This is further supported by the actions of the middle classes who have pulled out of communal responsibilities, often in part because state services are seen as inefficient and corrupt. As such the state uses the market as a new control mechanism. While there is a general withdrawal of the state it is not in the arena of control but rather in its position of responsibility for safeguarding all citizens, especially the weaker sections of society. The new economic realities have led to increased marketization across the public sector – commercialization of public services and the use of market proxies leading in turn to disaggregation, deregulation, commodification, an emphasis on measurable outputs, managerialism and accountability. This in turn delegitimizes the state. Neoliberalism is in effect the new 'common sense' that has replaced the social democracy of the post-war era (Giroux 2003). Globalization has allowed neoliberal market-oriented reforms to spread and it has become a Western hegemonic discourse that now dominates world economic relations, affecting state–society relations in developing countries.[11]

It was mentioned above that a reduction of the state is not unusual as globalization has changed the functions of the state. Gita Steiner Khamsi (2014) has written extensively about how aid politics and policy borrowing have brought the neoliberal model to countries like Pakistan. Today neoliberal theory literature looks less at citizens and more at consumers, and when it comes to rights it more often than not tends to operate on the basis of choice rather than rights. However, we do not argue here that neoliberalism is what has caused the increased absence of the state in Pakistan. Aid politics with a neoliberal agenda pushed in particular by Western development partners such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF) or the World Bank has reinforced and underpinned the absence of the state, but it did not cause it. This reinforcement is, however, crucial because it means that although Pakistan has embarked on a path where the social contract has lost its meaning and the social and political structures are being inexorably altered, the links between the state and today's young citizens will not be easy to reinstate.

> *The reality on the ground – the state is a parallel universe*
> *Subjugation, coercion and neglect. That is what the Pakistani state offers to its citizens.*
>
> (Student, Male, Lahore)